

ICELS

**Integrated Community Equipment
Loan Service**

**Nottingham City and
Nottinghamshire County**

**Specials Equipment Practice Guidance
ICELS Specials Panel**

August 2023 v3.

ICELS 'Specials' Equipment and Panel Process

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1 Introduction

The core business of ICELS is the provision of community equipment to meet significant assessed clinical need. Prescribers may be assessing under Social Care or NHS guidance/ legal frameworks. People who are assessed as falling outside the eligibility criteria within that guidance/legal framework are responsible for providing their own equipment, although advice and guidance may be given.

For all non-catalogue 'specials' equipment, prescribers and authorisers are expected to:

- Firstly, update themselves on the available standard stock catalogue range, and demonstrate exclusion of the use of standard stock ICELS catalogue items to meet assessed clinical needs.
- Secondly, (and only when eligible needs cannot be met by an existing item within the ICELS catalogue), use existing non- catalogue 'refurbished specials' stock. It is essential that refurbished stock is only used for those with an assessed clinical need, rather than being used because it is available.
- Lastly, (and only when 'refurbished specials' stock does not meet the need), consider purchasing new 'specials' equipment. Funding options for any new purchase 'specials', need to be considered early in the process.

If someone is in receipt of fully funded Continuing Health care funding for their care, then any subsequent specialist equipment must be funded by Health 'specials' equipment budgets not Social Care budgets.

Due to on-going budget restrictions, greater controls are necessary to ensure that ICELS only purchase new equipment when absolutely required. This means that the clinical and/or social care need must be clearly identified, and any item **must** fall within ICELS core business of **community equipment**.

2 ICELS Practice Guidance

- 2.1 All orders for special equipment must be recommended based on assessed clinical need, in line with current national guidance and legal frameworks. As part of our stewardship of Public Funds, Prescribers must not give individuals any guarantees of new purchases.
- 2.2 All equipment to be purchased as a 'special' should have a CE mark, a safe working load/maximum user weight limit, and a supplier name clearly marked on the equipment.
- 2.3 As part of the assessment process, it is the prescriber's responsibility to check that the equipment is suitable for the person, and that the safe working load / maximum user weight of the equipment is appropriate for that person.
- 2.4 It is expected that lower cost, low level items such as aids for daily living, should be self-purchased as they are not usually provided by ICELS. Advice can be given to clients on possible suppliers' catalogues or websites such as: British Red Cross, Boots, Argos, Asda, Mothercare, Lakeland, NRS Ways and Means, Medequip, Amazon, etc.
- 2.5 If an item costs more than £500 for adults and £1000 for children, (excluding VAT) quotes from **two** different suppliers must be obtained as part of the decision-making process; this is to comply with Financial Regulations. The only exception to this, is if an item is only available from a single manufacturer. There is a preferred supplier list available from ICELS. See section 5.
- 2.6 All special equipment orders must be approved and signed by one of the identified special authorisers within the ICELS Partnership.
- 2.7 **Prescribers must not** offer a colour choice¹. All colours must be neutral, dark and non-gender specific, i.e., preferably black, where available, or alternatively dark blue, dark brown, grey etc. All fabrics should be wipeable and /or waterproof, or washable as appropriate.
- 2.8 Individuals and their families/carers/care homes must be told that any item supplied to them is on **LOAN** and must be returned to ICELS when no longer required by that individual.
- 2.9 Individuals and their families/carers/care homes must be told that they are responsible for looking after all our loaned equipment and if items are found to have been misused, abused, or adapted in any way they could be liable for the full replacement cost and/or costs of repairs.
- 2.10 If an item is particularly complex and/or expensive, individuals need to be advised to contact their home insurance providers to get advice about insurance cover in the event of an incident.

¹ Colour choices are only allowable if a direct payment is being accessed. However, people do need to be reminded that the equipment does remain the property of ICELS and should be returned to ICELS when no longer required. Therefore, any colour choices ideally should be mindful of future reuse.

3 Ordering 'specials' equipment

Clinical staff within the ICELS team can offer support and advice to prescribers to assist with problem solving and discuss possible options/solutions. Either by using standard stock or existing 'refurbished specials'. Prescribers can contact the ICELS team on icesteam@nottscg.gov.uk to request support.

3.1 Checking for refurbished 'specials' equipment

Following an assessment of clinical need, the equipment prescriber needs to check with British Red Cross (BRC) to see if the required item, or a close technical equivalent (CTE) that meets the need, is already available in 'refurbished specials' stock. Prescribers can do this by emailing customercare@redcross.org.uk with the individuals webelms code, giving as much information as possible about the equipment required, including size, weight limit needed, and a product web-link where possible.

Please note the above does not apply to any Riser Recliner or Postural seating – see Appendix D for the revised seating process (March 2021).

Available specials can often be viewed within webelms, a 'How to View' guide is available within the full webelms guide available from either the webelms home page or the ICELS team.²

Refurbished equipment will be reserved in the stores, for a standard two-week period. An extension of this two-week period can be requested if additional component parts need to be ordered or if requests need to go to Panel. See appendix C for more detail.

Prescribers can arrange to visit stores if necessary, to view the equipment, and to identify the need for any additional component parts before ordering the item for the service user. Please see homepage on webelms for viewing times.

Be aware that any unauthorised orders cannot be processed by British Red Cross.

3.2 Ordering new non-catalogue equipment

If you have excluded standard catalogue and refurbished stock. You will need to proceed as follows:

- 3.2.1 Prescriber to consider the most cost-effective solution or options to the problem and to keep any solution as simple as possible, to reduce problems with service and maintenance going forward.
- 3.2.2 Prescriber to check the ICELS preferred supplier list. See section 5.

² Webelms refurb stock viewing, via stock category listing, SA (specials Adults) or SC (specials children) then by category, click on product code/s listed, click on 'available' under serial numbers, wait for page to load. The listing provides bar codes, descriptions, sizes and photos of potentially available items.

- 3.2.3 If there is no preferred supplier for your type of item, consult colleagues or ICELS for possible suppliers of products.
- 3.2.4 Prescriber to obtain quote/s from manufacturer/supplier. If necessary, prescribers should ask a company representative to carry out a **joint** visit to the client. **Prescribers need to make sure they advise the representative/supplier that all purchasing is done through the British Red Cross to include negotiated discounts.**
- 3.2.5 The ICELS Partnership do not expect prescribers to send an unaccompanied representative/supplier on equipment assessment/review/set up visits. The prescriber is accountable for the assessment and for checking post installation and that the item does meet their assessed need.
- 3.2.6 Highly complex electrical items may need to have a servicing and maintenance agreement purchasing at the same time. Consult the ICELS Partnership Manager or ICELS Senior Practitioner Occupational Therapists for further advice.
- 3.2.7 When completing the specials order form prescribers will need to provide the company name and address, product code, item name, size, and price.
- 3.2.8 ICELS will only agree to the purchase of new equipment when necessary. When new orders are received by ICELS/BRC they may be checked against currently available refurbished stock. Suitable items may have been returned to stock in the time taken to produce and authorise an order.
- 3.2.9 In the event of an appropriate item, or close technical equivalent item, having become available during the ordering process, the prescriber and their manager/authoriser will be informed by ICELS/BRC. A decision will then be jointly made by ICELS and the relevant manager/authoriser as to whether to issue the refurbished item or proceed with the new order. This could be influenced by the current budget position.

4 ICELS Specials Authorisers

- 4.1 All specials recommendations, new purchases or use of existing refurb stock, must be authorised by an ICELS specials authoriser. There is only a limited number of approved authorisers within ICELS. These are senior professionals within each organisation of the Partnership.
- 4.2 A full list of authorisers can be obtained from the ICELS team.
- 4.3 Any changes to the list must be approved by the ICELS Commissioners.

Please see process flowchart Section 7.

5 ICELS Preferred Suppliers List

This is a list of approved suppliers that has been chosen by ICELS, BRC and the ICELS CAG's. The list is available on webelms and updated regularly.

These suppliers have been chosen following partnership wide equipment evaluations and are known to provide a good level of after sales support. They have usually entered into purchasing agreements to guarantee improved response times, more rapid orders turnaround, and usually discounted prices.

The preferred suppliers might not always be the lowest cost option, but consideration has been given to ensure follow up support, product training and any possible needs for servicing, parts and maintenance. In the past it has been acknowledged that some cheaper products have been purchased, that have failed, and it's subsequently been very difficult to get repairs, replacements or follow up support.

It is recognised that this is not all inclusive and other alternatives to meet client needs may have to be considered dependent on circumstances.

Wherever possible, ICELS needs to try to have equipment which might be modular or easily compatible parts which make issuing of refurbished items run more smoothly. All fabric choices must be neutral and easy to keep clean. Experience has shown that this also reduces the amount of work prescribers need to do in sourcing equipment.

6 ICELS Specials Panel

Since April 2019, The ICELS Partnership Board requires that all recommendations over the designated financial thresholds must be reviewed by an ICELS Specials Panel. This is applicable to all service areas and all Partners Organisations. Specials authorisers from all partner organisations will be represented on the Panel.

The ICELS Partnership Support Team has been directed to administer the Panel and set up an out of panel process where appropriate and applicable, along with ICEL|S OT input to triage all recommendations.

See Appendix B for full details of how panel works and Terms of Reference.

7 ICELS Specials Order Forms

The ICELS Partnership Board has set the following Panel financial thresholds:

Adults	£500
Children's	£1000

Recommendations for all specials equipment must be submitted on Form A if under thresholds or Form B if over the thresholds.

All requests must be sent in to secure email: icesteam@nottsgov.uk

- The ICELS Clinical Team will carry out Triage on all submissions, consider if a recommendation can be completed Out of Panel (OOP) or if the request is more complex onto the Panel for consideration. It all depends on the case that has been presented, the value and or the equipment requested.
- Person sensitive information/clinical reasoning will be removed by ICELS before passing approved requests to BRC.
- Two quotes must be obtained for all equipment costing over £500 per item. These must be from different suppliers. The only exception to this is if the item is only available from one specific supplier.
- The forms have been created in WORD format and must be completed electronically and sent to ICELS in its word format. Authorisers can forward the forms to ICELS with a covering email as their authorisation signature.
- The forms have been designed so that they can be added/copied to Partners electronic records, so prescribers don't have to type up client notes twice.

7.1 ICELS Specials Form A – for items under financial thresholds

Must be completed for all new and refurbished items being recommended. Both sides **must** be completed in full and signed by a specials authoriser or they will not be processed.

Prescribers must provide clear clinical reasoning as justification for requesting all such items and advise what standard equipment has been tried first and why it doesn't meet the assessed need.

7.2 ICELS Specials Order Form B – for items over financial thresholds

Must be completed for all new and refurbished items where the value is **over** the financial thresholds, these requests will be triaged for OOP or submitted to the Panel.

All sides **must** be completed in full and signed by an approved ICELS specials authoriser or they will not be processed. Full explanation of clinical need is essential for Panel to understand what and why an item is being recommended. Remember that the Panel members will not know the individual or the circumstances being considered. Prescribers **must** include details of what standard catalogue or refurb equipment has been tried and **why** such items do not meet the assessed need.

As of March 2021, Form B has been updated to include additional pages which need to be completed if requesting Adults Seating. These pages replace the ICELS Adults seating minimum data sheet. This will reduce the duplication and the amount of information needed and speeds up potential seating provision. Please see Appendix D in this document for the revised adults seating pathway.

7.3 ICELS Form C - Options Appraisal Tool

It should be used where required, especially for high cost more complex items, as a method of recording all equipment considered as part of reaching recommendations. It can be stored within the individual's running records as a track of what equipment has been tried and considered to demonstrate step progression.

It should be used as evidence of the decision-making rationale which would be needed in the event of a query, subsequent challenge, or complaint. E.g., Specialist beds, high-cost unusual items, complex equipment decisions, etc.

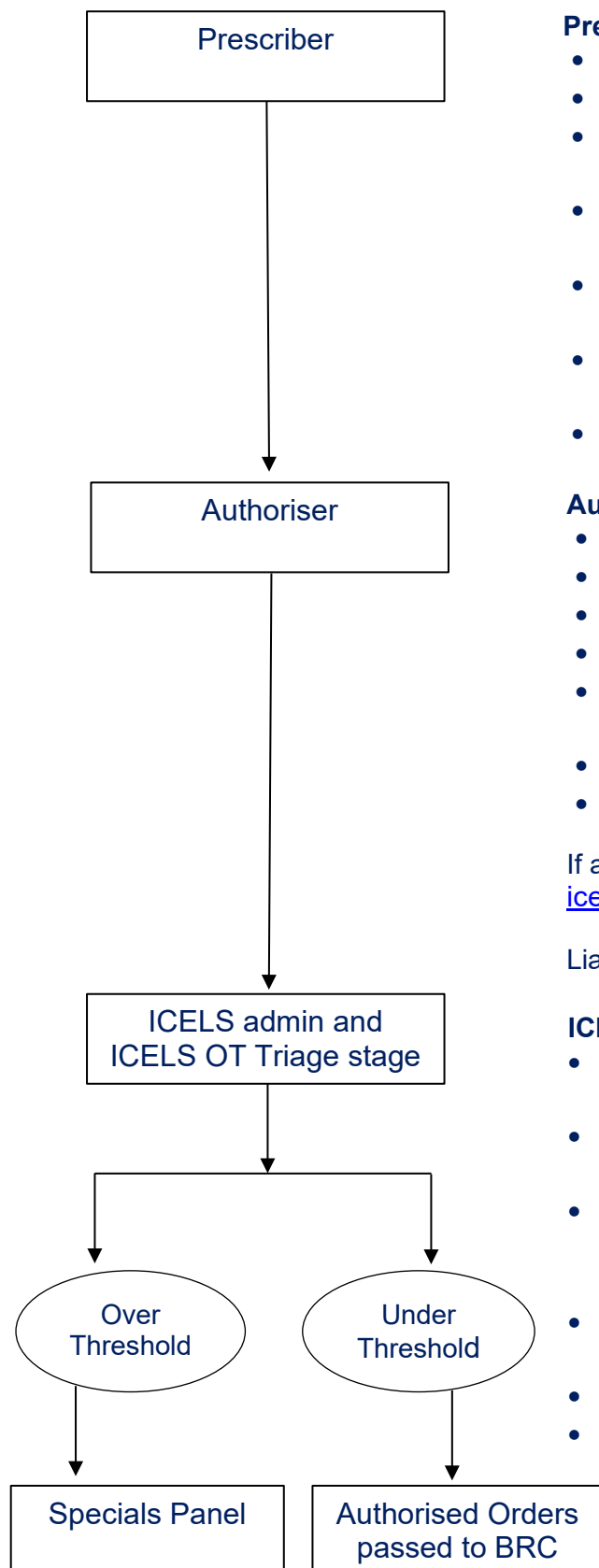
7.4 ICELS Form D/E – Response to Prescriber/Split Funding Agreement

Dual purpose form giving both the Panel Outcome and any Funding decisions agreed by the Panel. The Panel Outcome section is completed by the Panel admin, to be returned to the prescriber and the initial authoriser and provides feedback on the outcome of Panel decision.

If a request is approved, the Split Funding section of the form will be completed by Panel admin to go to BRC with approved orders where split funding has been agreed between partner organisations. (ICELS team will remove all the individual's sensitive info from all order forms before sending to BRC.)

Appendix A – Specials Flowchart

NB: A prescriber may only order reconditioned/new special if they have authority to order equivalent item from standard catalogue stock



Prescriber completes assessment:

- Consider statutory provision and clinical need.
- If not statutory, item should be self-funded.
- Must always consider and use standard catalogue equipment first, if possible.
- Must check if suitable alternative item in refurb, see Appendix D for seating pathway.
- Must source 2 quotes if over threshold and need new special purchase
- Prescriber must not give the individual any guarantees of new purchase
- Liaise with ICELS/BRC for advice

Authoriser discussion with Prescriber:

- Is it required under statutory provision?
- Is this to meet an essential clinical need?
- Should it be self-funded/Direct Payments?
- Can standard catalogue equipment be used?
- Is there a suitable item in Refurb specials that would meet the need?
- Is a new special purchase essential?
- Has sufficient evidence been provided?

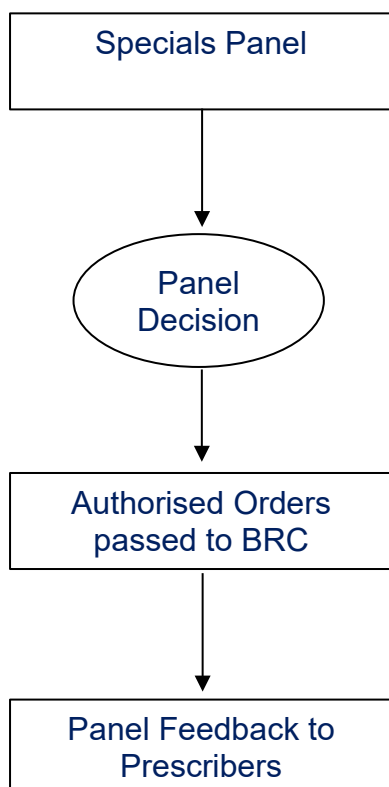
If agreed, once authorised, send Forms to:
icesteam@nottsgov.uk

Liaise with ICELS/BRC for advice

ICELS admin / OT Triage

- ICELS log all recommendations, checks CHC or joint funding status if applicable
- Recommendations under thresholds, if authorised and complete, passed to BRC to be ordered
- Recommendations over thresholds, pass through OT Triage stage – check request against existing ICELS refurb stock, advise of alternatives/parts
- Out of panel decisions, complete and authorised orders passed to BRC
- Panel decision required, taken to Panel
- Approved orders passed to BRC with funding identified

Pathway continued:



Specials Panel

- Panel considers recommendations:
 - Panel puts on hold, pending request for further information from prescriber
 - Panel considers if eligible for split funding
 - Panel turns down, provides feedback on decision
 - Panel approves recommendation
- Approved orders passed to BRC with funding identified, clinical pages removed for storage by ICELS

Post Panel

- ICELS admin separates clinical reasoning documents from Form B, to be stored for 36months and then destroyed.
- Outcomes recorded by ICELS, including finance
- Funding approved documentation completed and passed to BRC with order and relevant quote.
- BRC to process order, splitting costs between partners if/where identified
- Panel outcome feedback sent to Prescribers and original Authoriser

Complaints/Challenges/Reconsiderations

- Recommendations which have been turned down by panel
- Prescribers can resubmit with additional information asking for the Panel to reconsider
- Prescribers may be asked to attend panel to present additional information and respond to questions

Appendix B - ICELS Specials Panel Terms of Reference and Process

Since April 2019 the ICELS Partnership Board requires that all recommendations over the designated financial thresholds must be reviewed by an ICELS Specials Panel. This is applicable to all service areas and all Partners Organisations and specials authorisers from all partner organisations will be represented on the Panel.

The ICELS Partnership Support Team has been directed to administer the Panel process, set up an out of panel process where applicable, and ICELS OT input to triage all recommendations.

The item being recommended must provide the most cost-effective solution and offer value for money.

Terms of Reference

Chaired by: ICELS Partnership Manager/Senior Practitioner OTs – non-voting
Administration: ICELS Admin

Members to cover both Adults and Paeds:

Operational Representatives from Health: City, County and Bassetlaw
Nottingham City Council
Nottinghamshire County Council

Quorate: Minimum of 2 voting members, one from Health, one for Local Authorities
Maximum 3 from Health and 3 from Local Authorities
All on panel are representing the Partnership not their own organisations.

Purpose

1. To review and authorise recommendations for special equipment purchases that will cost over the stated financial threshold, whether as new purchases or use of existing refurbished stock
2. To consider whether such requests fall under statutory and legal requirements to provide.
3. If not, to advise alternatives or advise where items must be self-purchased
4. To agree whether such costs should be charged to the prescribing organisation or split funded between different organisations. This is dependent on the clinical rationale provided by prescriber and current known parameters used for split funding.
5. To request further information from prescribers if they are unable to decide.
6. To advise prescribers of panel outcomes, including any decisions made about joint funding.
7. To prepare feedback to prescribers for any requests that are turned down
8. Identify items which are repeatedly requested, for consideration by the ICELS Clinical Advisory Groups, for possible inclusion in the ICELS standard equipment catalogue.

Administration

The panel administrator will log all submissions and check they are complete and compliant with Data Protection. If any individuals are flagged as being potentially fully CHC funded or joint funded for their care, this will be checked with the relevant CCG or Local Authority. All recommendations will pass through the OT Triage stage before going onto panel. If any documents are incomplete or the reasoning is not robust enough, requests will be returned to the prescriber along with guidance on what additional information is required.

If recommendations fall within the **‘Out of Panel’** remit, they will be signed off by the ICELS Partnership Manager and/or Senior Practitioner OT's to be passed direct to BRC.

Once recommendations are fully complete, the panel admin will circulate them to the Panel members, usually 24-48hours before the panel date.

Following consideration at Panel, the administrator will:

- Record the outcomes and financial decisions made
- Separate the clinical notes from submitted documents to be filed
- Send the approved order forms and quotes to BRC along with the Split funding form if applicable
- Send the panel outcome form to the prescriber and their initial authoriser

ICELS OT Triage

The ICELS clinical team has been tasked with carrying out a range of simple checks to ensure cost effectiveness and usage of existing refurbished stock where suitable and possible.

The ICELS OT triage stage will:

- Check against existing refurb stock and advise prescribers of existing or alternatives
- Identify any requests that may not need go to panel and could be agreed Out of Panel.
- Make recommendations where appropriate.

Out of Panel

Some requests can be dealt with as an ‘Out of Panel Decisions’ such as:

- Urgent Clinical need, however, specials are not normally considered to be urgent
- Children’s Seating clinics where simple sign off is needed to send out assessed item (i.e.: Notts County Council)
- Component parts for larger items that are needed to complete existing items
- Simple replacements and repairs
- Requests that clearly demonstrate the needs, discusses all options considered and presents an appropriate summary, therefore don’t appear to warrant submission to panel for further consideration.
- Other examples may be added as the process develops

All such requests will be signed off by the ICELS Partnership Manager or Senior Practitioner OT and then sent retrospectively to Panel for review and final sign off.

Meeting Arrangements

Panels will run every 1 - 2 weeks utilising electronic meeting methodology (conference or video calls) where available. If not available for some members, suitable meeting room facilities will be provided at varying locations to accommodate panel members. These arrangements may change depending on the volume of requests needing review. Papers will be sent to that week's panel members usually 24-48 hours in advance.

Panel members are expected to have reviewed circulated recommendations prior to the meetings.

The panel chair will direct the meeting, ensuring all present have opportunity to contribute to decision making, that a consensus is reached and then subsequently summarised. Experts on certain areas of equipment may be drafted in to assist with decision making on complex cases or items which fall out of most panel members areas of expertise.

The panel can decide the funding of an item if the clinical reasoning demonstrates such a need. The following would normally apply:

- If a person is fully CHC funded for their care, then only Health will fund the item.
- If there is a jointly funded care package between Health and Social Care, then the item may also be funded on the same percentage split basis.
- If the item is wholly for pressure care / postural needs then Health would normally fund it.

Panel may request additional information from the prescribers to gain greater clarity so may delay a decision.

Once a decision has been reached on each case, the Panel admin will record the decision and complete a Panel outcome form that will be returned to the requesting prescriber.

Accountability

The Panel will report to the ICELS Partnership Board and Lead Commissioners. The ICELS Partnership Manager is required to produce regular reports on activity and expenditure to the ICELS Lead Commissioners.

Urgent Emergency Requests

It should be noted that a special equipment item is not deemed as urgent or essential for discharge. Our standard catalogue range should meet most people's needs even if only in the short term, whilst an alternative is being considered.

There would have to be an exceptional need for special requests to be treated as urgent. That could be due to breakdown of an existing special and a call out or repair may need expediting. In such cases, prescribers need to contact either the ICELS Partnership Manager or ICELS Senior Prac OT's for advice.

Reconsideration

If a request is turned down by the panel, the Panel will provide feedback to the prescriber on the reasons why.

Prescribers and their Authoriser may seek to resubmit for reconsideration. If this is being considered, prescribers **must** ensure they can provide additional valid clinical reasoning that will substantially change the position and understanding of the Panel members.

Complaints

If an individual wishes to make a complaint, their prescriber must advise and direct them to follow their local Health or Local Authority complaints process.

Appendix C – Use of Specials Refurb

Use of existing refurbished Specials stock is subject to the following parameters:

1. If Prescribers want to trial a complex/high spec item, they need to do a joint visit with the company rep asking them to provide the equipment to be tested. Do not ask for the item to be taken from ICELS refurb stock, this practice is expensive and removes the item from being available to meet someone else's need.
2. Prescribers may only access specials refurb items which are comparable to their existing standard catalogue equipment access. I.e.; if they are a physio they can access refurb physio items.
3. Prescribers should only request items which they are competent in assessing for and able to advise people on their safe usage.
4. Refurb items requested are subject to the **same** process as new purchases, order request forms must be fully completed, and those items valued as over financial thresholds must be submitted to the Specials Panel.
5. Be aware that as with new purchases, there are no guarantees that Panel will approve a request to provide an item from Refurb.

How to view Specials refurb items on webelms

Download the webelms guide for prescribers which includes 'How to view' guide from the home page of webelms or contact the ICELS team to have a copy sent to you.

Viewing and Requesting Specials Refurb listed on webelms

If prescribers have viewed an item on webelms and wish to reserve it for their client, they need to:

1. Email customercare@redcross.org.uk stating their name, PIN code, and clients webelms code.
2. If the item is still available BRC, will reserve the item for them for approximately 2 weeks. The reserve will be longer if additional parts/repairs are needed or if the request must go to Panel.
3. Prescriber must consider the value of the item if purchased as new. If the item would be less than current financial thresholds (£500 adults, £1000 children) then they must complete **FORM A** in **full** and seek authorisation from an ICELS approved specials Authoriser.
4. If the item would cost over the financial thresholds, the prescriber must complete **FORM B** in **full** detail, seek authorisation from an ICELS approved specials authoriser. The request will have to go to the ICELS Specials Panel for discussion and final approval.

Appendix D – Notts Adults Pathway for refurbished and new purchase seating

